As the purdah became less porous through the interaction of the zenana with the Rajput women that Akbar married, these women nonetheless retained their independence of thought and even action. The work of historian Ruby Lal has shown that there were interesting ways in which these women managed to ‘escape’ the purdah, and I have written of these episodes in this book. There were subtler ways of resistance too, and Akbar always had to be supremely wary of displeasing these powerful matriarchs when he was experimenting with his religious ideas, punishing the ulema, or reining in a favoured prince. The contours of Akbar’s wives remain more shadowy, but not yet indistinct. Abu’l Fazl was fierce in his censorship of these women and there were other writers, like Badauni, who railed against the influence that the Padshah’s ‘Hindu wives’ had on his food habits, his clothes and his very thoughts. There are the equally petulant writings of the Jesuits, who blamed Akbar’s women for his resistance to the charms of conversion. There are also the farmans of these women, their patronage of temples, the influence they exercised on behalf of priests and clerics. Through these fragile sources a picture can yet be gleaned. And there are extraordinary women present amongst Akbar’s adversaries too, such as Rani Durgavati and Chand Sultan. As always, I find that to acknowledge the influence and power of women in a man’s life never diminishes the man, quite the contrary.

The discovery of the evolution of the personality of Akbar through these many phases of his life was one of the truly surprising discoveries in the writing of this biography. As he interacted with the multitudes around him and their different truths, Akbar borrowed from their various symbols and beliefs. At different stages of his life, Akbar was a staunch Muslim ruler, a Timurid prince, a Sufi divine, a Hindustani raja, and a mujaddid (reformer) of the second Islamic millennium. To be able to inhabit these many roles, Akbar was buoyed and surrounded by a legion of men and women, who marked time to the cadence of his journey, and shaped him in ways big and small. This book is also a record of those men and women, the great, teeming, noisome mass of humanity and creatures that were so essential to the moulding of Akbar even as he maintained within himself an enigmatic, entirely unknowable, and still core. Similarly, the culture that the Mughals created did not magically appear from the darkness, perfect and luminous in every respect as Abu’l Fazl would have us believe. It came about through trial, experiment, chance, canny calculation, and careful balance. It is these